Substance Harm across New Zealand

What is Substance Harm?

Substance Harm refers to the negative health, social, and economic impacts associated with the use of alcohol and other substances.

It affects:

- The individual
- The Community
- The Wider Public



Differences in Substance Harm

Our research question tackles substance harm across NZ, particularly police districts.

Do districts differ from each other? Are they all the same? Does one district favour one drug type above others?

These are the questions our research aims to answer.

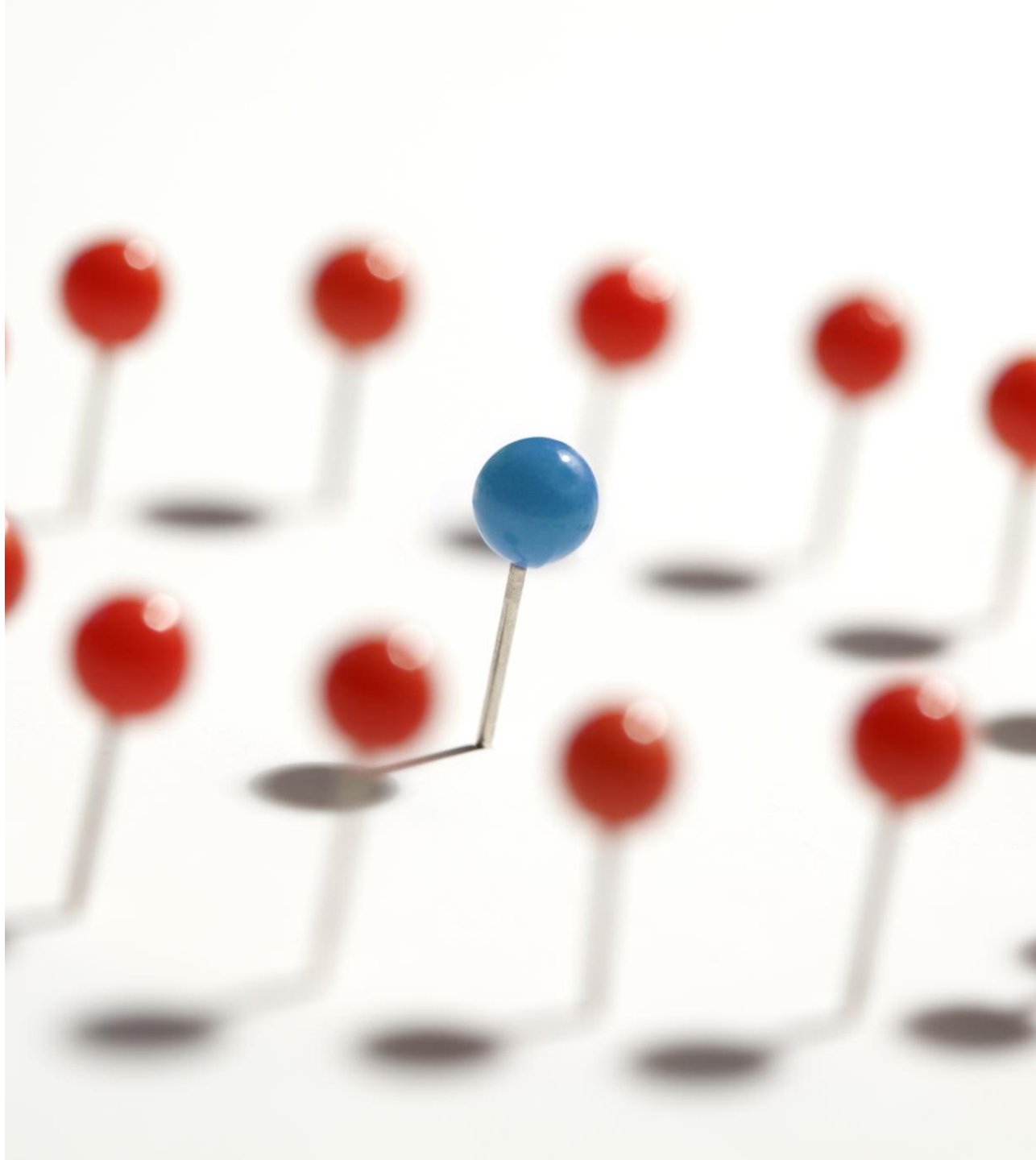


Population Adjustment

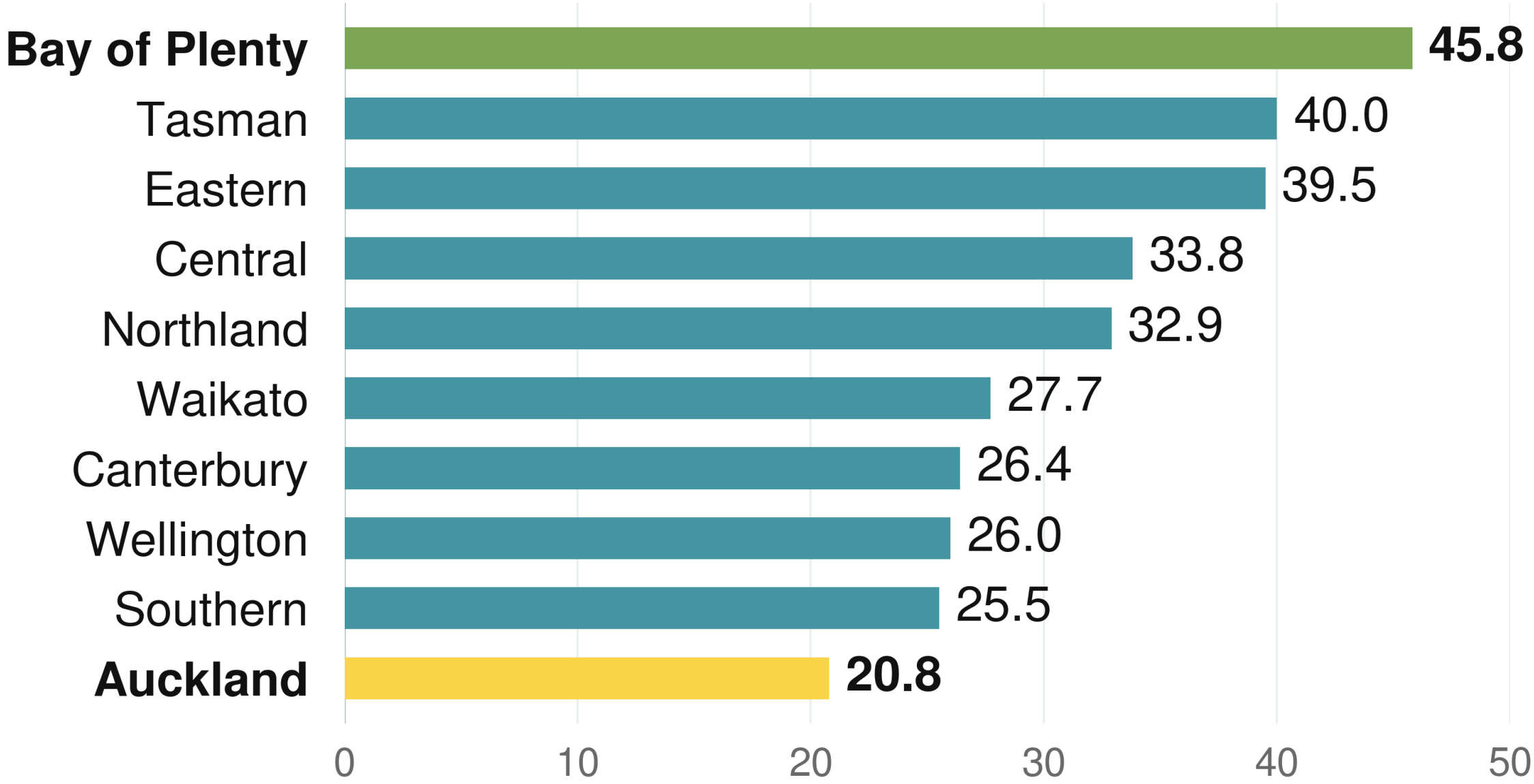
Regions can (and will) differ in population. This can make comparisons difficult between districts.

We adjusted for this by converting our data in **rates per 10,000 people**.

This allows us to fairly compare between districts.



Police actions per 10,000 people



Regions differ in drug mix, not only volume

Bay of Plenty

Cannabis
46.4

Methamphetamine
23.3

Auckland

Cannabis
16.5

Methamphetamine
10.0

Tasman

Cannabis
101.5

Methamphetamine
28.0

Southern

Cannabis
51.8

Methamphetamine
19.2

Police actions per 10,000 people (per year), 2016 – 2023

The police response to the same drug depends on the district

Cannabis



Lowest: Canterbury, 47.6%

Highest: Southern, 69.5%

Methamphetamine

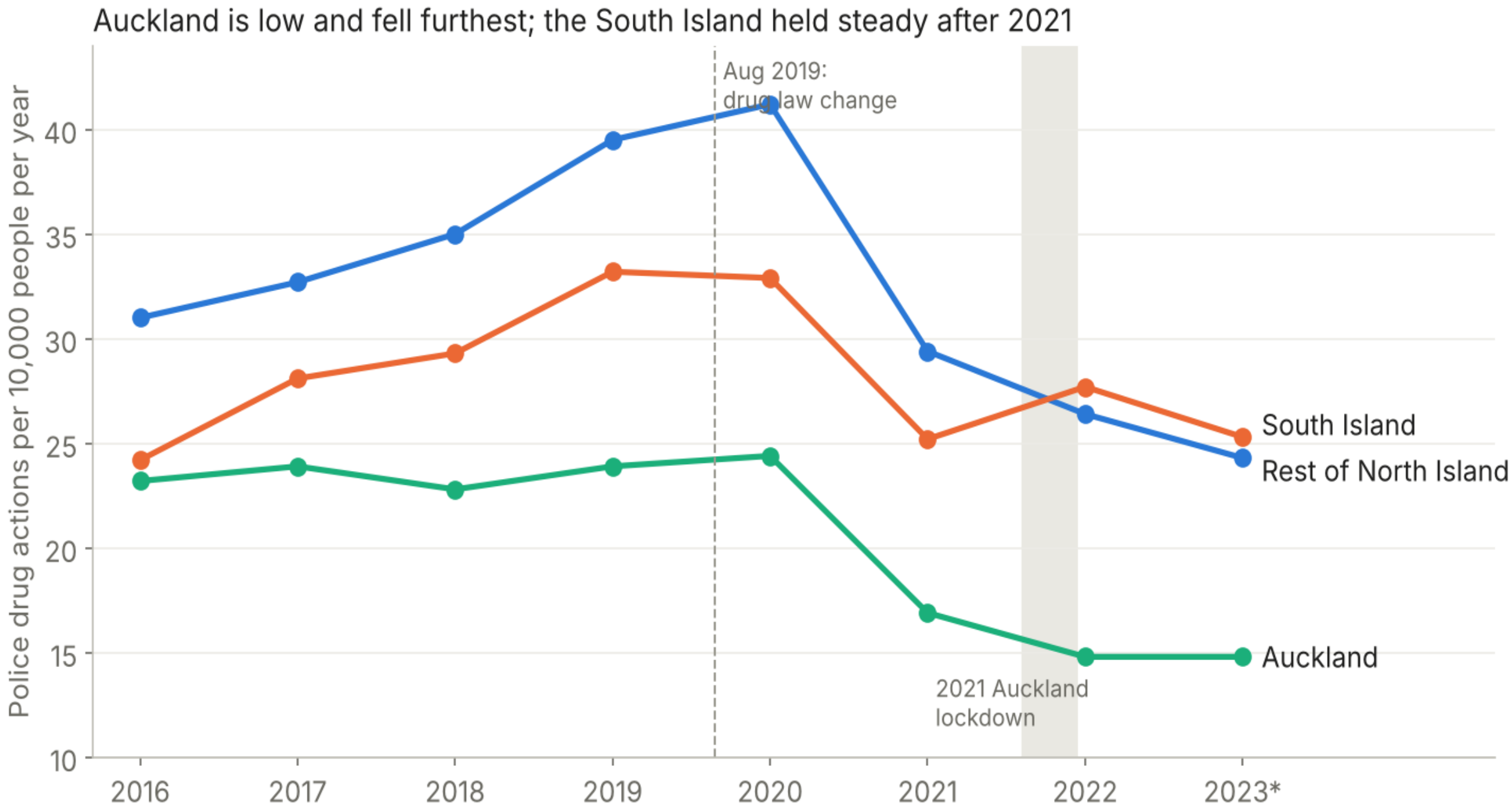


Lowest: Canterbury, 12.2%

Highest: Southern, 34.0%

30% → 54%

Alternative action across all drug actions, Jan 2016 to Oct 2017 against Sep 2019 onward, after the 2019 amendment.



*2023 = Jan–Jun, annualised. Source: NZ Police, Policing of Drugs in NZ (policedata.nz); Stats NZ population estimates (approx. shares).

Ethics

- To clarify, **Police actions measure policing, not crime or drug use.**
- We avoided ethnicity-based conclusions in this presentation because in our police data set there were no ethnic differences in prosecution vs alternative action.
- This is further backed up by the health survey data. As the differences by ethnicity, we confounded by serval variables.

Limitations

Our police actions data ends in 2023. We had to augment this with a secondary dataset (that measures something slightly different) to extend that data to 2026.

- Dataset: NZ Police RCOS "Proceedings (offender demographics)“ from policedata.nz

Police district boundaries only approximately match regional councils.

The 2019 law change and COVID (2020–21) both disrupt the usage trend

Recommendations

01

Our research suggests that responses to substance harm should consider differences between police districts, rather than relying only on a North–South Island comparison.

02

We recommend using police data alongside wastewater and health evidence to identify local needs, then directing additional treatment and community support to areas where service gaps are confirmed.

03

Police, health services and community organisations should work together to connect people with early support and addiction treatment.